LaunchGate

Give Mastercard's own engineers the promise it already makes to partners.

A policy-aware deployment control plane. Agents prepare. Rules decide. People approve.

Customer: Mastercard · Consulting partner: EY · Built on Microsoft Azure and GitHub

THE HOOK

Money moves in under a second. Ideas wait eight months.

< 1 second

to authorize a cardholder's transaction, billions of times a year

15 days

Product Express promise to fintechs: a card program live, status visible to every party

6 to 8 months

12 handoffs before an internal team can start building. Reported in Discovery.

Same company. Same guardrails. The difference is whether the path is designed or inherited.

Product Express: mastercard.com (15 days after due diligence and contract) · Discovery with Mastercard Business Development, 12 Oct 2026

TEAM GARDEN STATE

Five builders, one brief

Azra Bano
Engagement lead · API, rules and readiness model

Melanie
Product and front end · portal and Vercel deployment

Jayden
Cloud · Azure Static Web Apps and delivery

Adrian
AI · Azure AI Foundry agent, risk memo, Bicep

[Name 5]
[Role]

WHERE WE HAVE WORKED

[Logo 1] [Logo 2]

[Logo 3] [Logo 4]

[Logo 5] [Logo 6]

Replace with employer or university logos (two per row).

THE PROBLEM, IN MASTERCARD'S NUMBERS

Compliance is re-proven by hand, twelve times in a row

12
handoffs to get a development environment

6 to 8
months from request to a usable environment

1
handoff is the ideal state, in the customer's words

0
tolerance for skipping a guardrail



"Deployment is not enough. It also includes policy and orchestration."



"Redo the whole process if someone leaves the company."



"Security guardrails. We can't come up with an idea and just ship it out."

Discovery interview with Maria, Business Development, Mastercard, 12 Oct 2026. The 6 to 8 month figure is treated as the end-to-end readiness cycle, to confirm in a pilot.

VALIDATED OUTSIDE THE ROOM

Approval chains, not servers, are the delay

78%

of engineering teams wait a day or more for DevOps help; 16% wait a week or more

Port, State of Internal Developer Portals 2025

81

steps, 3 tickets and a change request to ship one line of code at Morgan Stanley

Team Topologies, Jan 2026 (Gus Paul, Morgan Stanley)

90%+

of major changes approved by change boards; some firms rejected none all year

UK FCA, Implementing Technology Change, 2021

58

working days per quarter spent on compliance audits; 3 days per evidence request

Telos / Vanson Bourne survey, 2020

Gartner: 80% of large software engineering organizations will have platform engineering teams by 2026.

WHAT COMPETITORS AND PEERS ALREADY DID

Regulated banks fixed this with policy as code

Capital One

3 months → minutes

average development environment build time; built Cloud Custodian because every new cloud service needed its certs signed off by hand

AWS case study; InfoWorld 2024

JPMorgan Chase

6 to 18 months → codified

per cloud service approval before controls became standard questions, Terraform and tests; TrueCD targets any change live in under an hour

FINOS 2019; VentureBeat 2025

Visa

4 weeks

Fintech Fast Track onboarding by reducing onboarding conditions; Trusted Agent Protocol for agentic commerce

Visa newsroom 2018, 2025

Deutsche Bank

350+ policies as code

3,000+ developers consuming cloud autonomously, 500,000+ Terraform runs

HashiCorp case study

Amex: new platforms enter a Landing Zone then a Target Zone with enterprise controls as code (americanexpress.io, Sep 2026).

THE INSIGHT

Mastercard already runs this model. Just not for itself.



Externally: Product Express

- One governed request
- Pre-certified partners, fewer onboarding conditions
- Status visible to all parties, across all phases
- Card program live in as fast as 15 days



Internally: twelve handoffs

- Twelve people, in sequence, each re-checking policy
- Knowledge lives in people; attrition restarts the chain
- No single view of what is blocking a program
- 6 to 8 months before a partner program can start

"Trust cannot be implied. It must be proven." Mastercard, Verifiable Intent, March 2026. We apply the same standard to infrastructure changes.

OUR SOLUTION: LAUNCHGATE

Agents prepare. Rules decide. People approve.



1 Ask once

A business owner or engineer answers a few plain questions. Secure defaults applied.



2 Rules decide

A deterministic readiness model scores risk; every rule names the control it cites and the fix.



3 Agent prepares

Azure AI Foundry agent on an open model drafts the Bicep and a risk memo. Read-only.



4 People approve

Only the approvals that must stay human, in parallel. A GitHub gate enforces it.



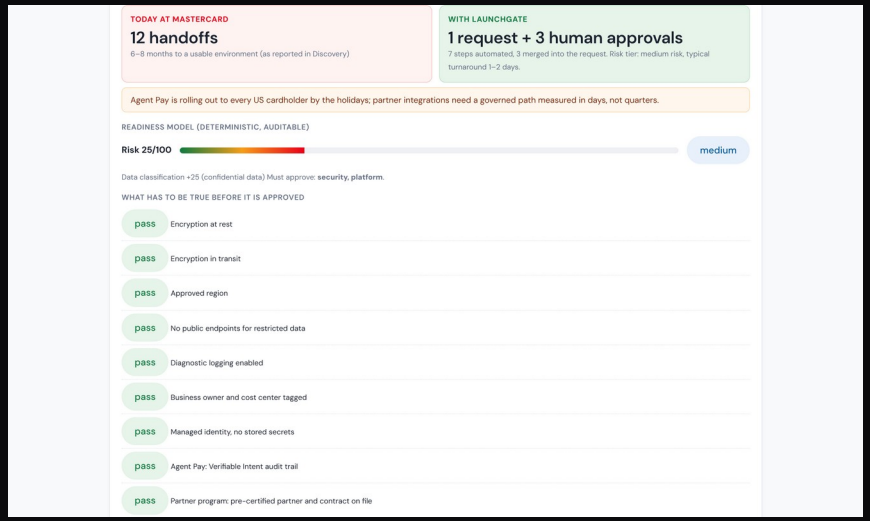
5 Everything logged

Append-only audit trail; the evidence pack a partner bank asks for is already written.

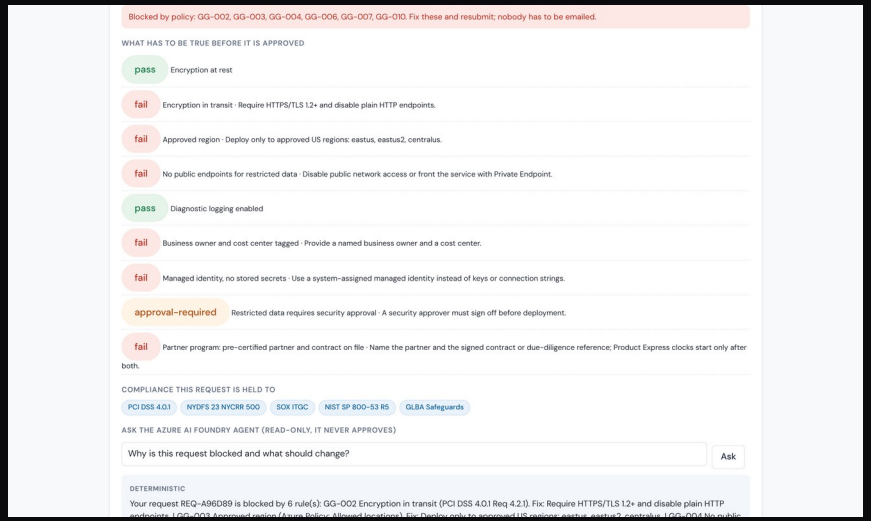
Twelve handoffs become one request plus one or two human approvals. Eight steps automated, three merged into the request. Nothing deploys without a person.

LIVE DEMO

Partner program to governed go-live, in minutes



Business owner view: today versus LaunchGate, risk tier, who must approve, and what has to be true.

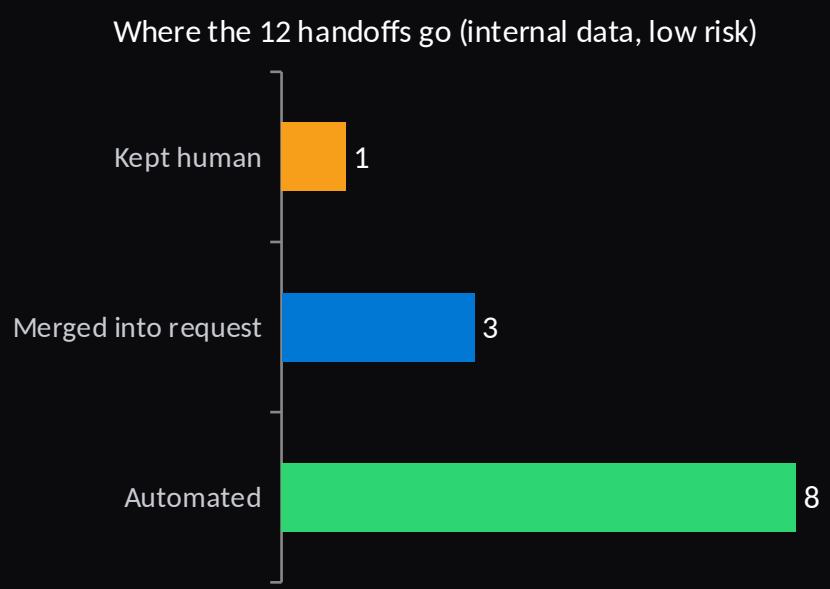


Misconfigured program: blocked with the exact rules and controls, and the Foundry agent explains the fix.

Scenarios: fintech card program · Agent Pay airline integration · internal service · misconfigured program

UNDER THE HOOD

A transparent model sets the human review



Readiness model
Six weighted factors (data class, exposure, credentials, residency, transport, observability) give a 0 to 100 score and a tier. Every point is auditable.

Rule engine
Ten rules as code in the Azure Policy schema. Same input, same result. Each cites PCI DSS 4.0.1, NIST 800-53, CIS Azure or a Mastercard standard.

Foundry agent
Open model (Phi-4) on Azure AI Foundry writes the risk memo and answers "why am I blocked". It cannot approve or deploy.

Agent Pay pack
Verifiable Intent audit trail required; agent governance review added as a thirteenth, human, step.

SECURITY AND RESPONSIBLE AI

Zero Trust by design

Identity

Roles from Microsoft Entra ID. Requester, security, platform, compliance. A requester can never approve their own request.

Secrets and data

No stored credentials: managed identity and DefaultAzureCredential. Synthetic data only; no cardholder data enters LaunchGate. Purview labels pick the rule pack.

Observability

Append-only audit of every transition, actor and rule, with export. No secrets in logs. Defender for Cloud scores the deployed environment.

AI guardrails

Agent is read-only, grounded on the request and rule results, refuses off-topic questions, cites rule IDs. Deterministic fallback if the model is down.

Human accountability

Pass or fail comes from versioned rules, never a model. Only humans approve. Only approved requests can deploy; a GitHub environment rule enforces it.

Governance

Rules cite PCI DSS 4.0.1, NYDFS 500, SOX ITGC, NIST 800-53 R5, GLBA. Changing a rule is itself a reviewed change in a pilot.

MICROSOFT TECHNOLOGY, AND HOW WE USED IT

Built on Azure and GitHub, with Copilot at the keyboard

Azure AI Foundry + Azure OpenAI

Agent Service running an open model (Phi-4) for the risk memo and explainer. Swappable to Llama 3.3 or Mistral Large.

Azure Functions + Static Web Apps + Cosmos DB

Serverless API behind a stateless core, React portal, append-only audit store. Same code also runs on Vercel.

Azure Policy + Defender for Cloud

Rule format borrowed from Azure Policy definitions; Defender's regulatory standards (PCI DSS 4, NIST 800-53 R5) for the pilot, including multicloud.

Microsoft Entra ID + Teams

Role model and separation of duties; adaptive-card approvals and Entra ID Governance access packages in the pilot.

GitHub Copilot, Actions, Advanced Security

Copilot instructions in the repo encode the rule schema; coding agent scaffolded modules; Actions deploy; environment protection rules enforce the human gate.

Microsoft Fabric + Purview + Azure Deployment Environments

Pilot path: readiness dashboard, sensitivity labels, real governed provisioning from a Bicep catalog.

Prototype uses synthetic data. Rules are illustrative and cite public standards; a pilot loads Mastercard's own catalogue into the same schema.

RETURN ON INVESTMENT

Saving money, by Maria's own test

The model, with inputs labelled

- Reported: 6 to 8 month cycle, ~12 handoffs per request
- Assumed: N programs per year; most of the cycle is waiting, not work
- Value per program = months saved × (partner revenue brought forward + reviewer time + engineer idle time)
- Illustration: 25 programs/yr × 4 months saved = 100 program-months recovered per year
- Industry benchmark for evidence effort: 58 working days per quarter on audits (Telos)

Time

Months of waiting per program become days. Capital One: 3 months to minutes.

Cost

Repeat reviewer work and idle engineering time removed; evidence written once.

Revenue timing

Partner programs and Agent Pay integrations go live sooner; BD quotes dates it can keep.

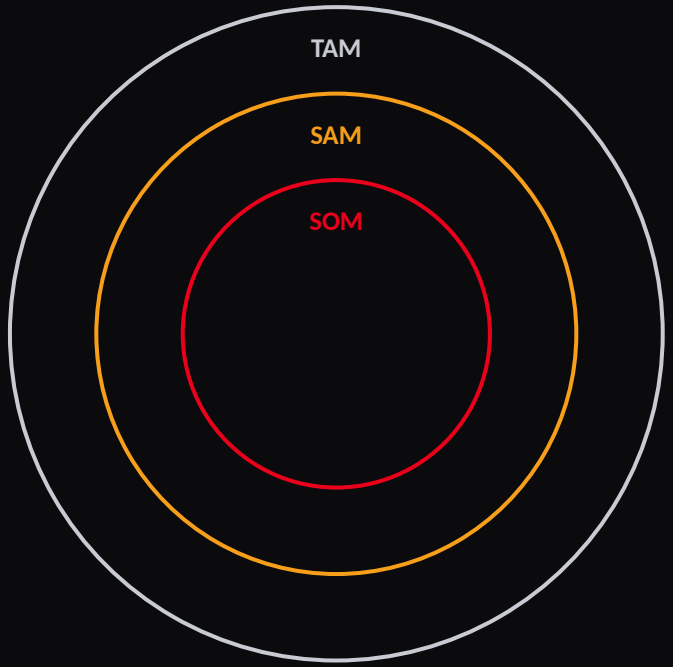
Risk

Same answer every time, full audit trail, fewer audit findings and no process restart on attrition.

The prototype counts handoffs removed and minutes per request so a 90-day pilot can price the real savings. Request volume is the first number a pilot confirms.

WHERE IT APPLIES

Start with partner programs, then every change



TAM — Every environment and program change at Mastercard: tens of thousands of workloads on OpenShift, AWS and Azure; every partner launch

SAM — Partner card programs and Agent Pay integrations in North America: 170+ fintech partners in Engage; Agent Pay to all US cardholders

SOM — 90-day pilot: one business unit, the real rule catalogue, Teams approvals, Azure Deployment Environments

Beyond Mastercard: Gartner expects 80% of large engineering organizations to run platform teams by 2026; the same control plane pattern applies to any regulated enterprise.

WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

A 90-day pilot that measures the real number

Days 1 to 30

Load Mastercard's rule catalogue into the schema with the Policy Copilot; security owns the rules.

Days 31 to 60

Entra ID Governance approvals in Teams; GitHub environment gate; Defender for Cloud scoring.

Days 61 to 90

Real provisioning through Azure Deployment Environments; Fabric dashboard reports cycle time per program.



The ask

A sponsor in Business Development and one in Platform Security, one business unit, and the number Discovery could not give us: programs per year. Target in pilot: 12 handoffs to 1 request plus required approvals; readiness from months to days.

Thank you

Microsoft, for the platform and the room. Mastercard, for a real problem and a straight answer. EY, for making us earn the scope.

Team Garden State · Azra Bano, Melanie, Jayden, Adrian, [Name 5]

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